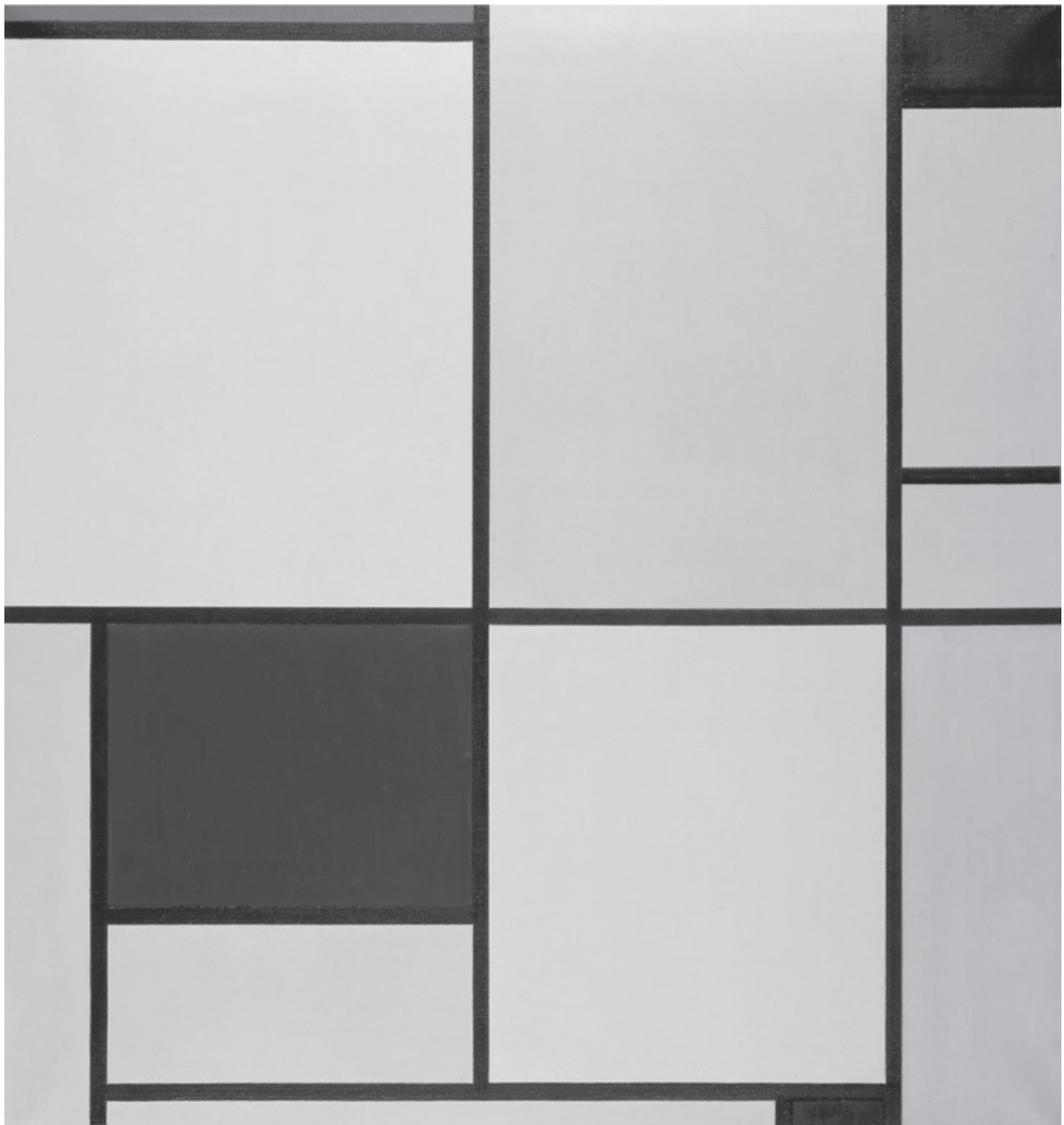


De Stijl/Neo-Plasticism

In 1917 in the Netherlands, Mondrian, Theo van Doesburg (1883–1931) and Bart van der Leek (1876–1958) formed a group with some other artists, designers and architects. De Stijl ('The Style') intended to create the most refined lines, shapes and forms possible, simplifying the elements of paintings, designs and buildings, paring everything down to simple, uncluttered contours and minimal colours. Mondrian, the most original of the group, aimed to develop a new 'visual language' that everyone could appreciate, expressing spiritual balance and universal rhythms.

Influenced by Theosophy (which taught that a person's thoughts generate coloured auras around them), Mondrian set out his theory in a series of articles in the periodical *De Stijl*. For him, yellow symbolized the sun's energy, blue suggested the universe, and red represented the solidity of the Earth. Horizontal lines are feminine and vertical lines are masculine. He called his abstract style Neo-Plasticism, and used just the three primary colours and grids of black vertical and horizontal lines on a white ground.



Mondrian, *Tableau 1*, 1921